

WHERE THE MIND HARBOURS fear, demons fly in.

“In a post-apocalyptic world, the few surviving humans lived in fear of the sentient AI that now controlled the ruins of civilisation. The machines had become twisted and malevolent, hunting down any humans they could find, and turning them into fuel for their own survival.”

This is not a narration from a chilly Nolaesque movie. It’s not from a dystopian novel, either. It’s a two-line horror story ‘written’ by ChatGPT, the new generative AI chatbot created by OpenAI that has got everyone delighted with its possibilities, and equally struck extreme fear amongst us, including the high and mighty.

The end of humanity is nigh, they say. ‘They’ are not doomsday-predicting punks or lunatics with crazed eyes pounding your town square. They are successful people, uncommonly rich, and possess some of the most brilliant minds in the field of science and technology. The most famous is Elon Musk, among the world’s richest men. Calling AI a fundamental risk to civilisation, Musk had sounded the alarm at the highest possible pitch known to mankind: “Mark my words, AI is far more dangerous than nukes.”

That was in 2022. In 2023, Musk has co-signed an open letter—with more than 1,000 people, including cognitive scientist Gary Marcus and Apple Co-founder Steve Wozniak—addressed to AI developers working on systems more powerful than ChatGPT. It asks for a pause in the development of powerful AI till better controls are in place. It says AI developers should work with policymakers to accelerate development of robust AI governance systems, including provenance and watermarking systems to help distinguish real from synthetic, liability for AI-caused harm and well-resourced institutions for coping with the dramatic economic and political disruptions (especially to democracy) that AI will cause.

For the record, ChatGPT is based on the GPT-3.5 (that’s short for generative pre-trained transformer). GPT-4, which was launched by OpenAI on March 14, 2023, processes information way faster than ChatGPT. A demo at the launch showed that GPT-4 can beat 90 per cent of humans in the world’s toughest competitive exams.

If GPT-4 is so good, what could GPT-5 bring, many wonder. And that’s the fear, especially in the absence of rules. But OpenAI Founder Sam Altman, in an address at MIT, pooh-poohed the concerns and said that there are no plans to develop GPT-5 for now. But

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PER GOLDMAN SACHS